



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Chesterton Academy of the Annunciation
School Website: <https://www.chestertonannunciation.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools (ACCS) or the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Chesterton Academy Annunciation MD 21788 (Annunciation High School, Emmitsburg, MD) presents a clearly classical Catholic program in public-facing materials. Public materials emphasize a Catholic, liturgical life (daily Mass, Rosary, Adoration, Examen), a theologically grounded identity, and a classical, formation-driven mission (formation of virtue and wisdom through a classical curriculum and Socratic inquiry). Evidence indicates engagement with the liberal-arts framework (classical curriculum, Socratic method, memorization/recitation, and a Great-Books orientation implied by references to the Great Conversation and classical texts). Faculty portrayals present teachers as virtuous models and mentors, and the school emphasizes partnership with families and active parish/community life. Tuition-related information and MSDE/NAPCIS recognition further anchor its identity as a Catholic classical school. Overall, the school qualifies as CLASSICAL across most dimensions, with particularly strong alignment in Religious & Metaphysical Foundations, School Purpose & Goal, Curriculum, Faculty, and Parents & Community. Element 4 shows substantial classical pedagogy signals (Socratic methods and formation-focused practices) but appears to lack explicit public documentation of every pedagogical hallmark (e.g., some elements of Scholé/restful learning or full cataloging of all classical pedagogy practices). The aggregate assessment is CLASSICAL.

Key signals contributing to CLASSICAL status:

- Religious and metaphysical foundations: daily Mass, regular liturgical life, Catholic formation, Magisterium-aligned teaching, daily prayer, Rosary, Examen, adoration, novena practices.
- Purpose and goals: explicit aim to form virtue and wisdom through study of the true, the good, and the beautiful; formation over mere information.
- Curriculum: public notes of a classical curriculum rooted in Catholic faith; Socratic method cited for pursuing truth; stated emphasis on classical education and Great Conversation.
- Pedagogy: Socratic dialogue appears in public materials; a classical, formation-driven approach is implied by the curriculum and liturgical integration.
- Faculty: faculty pages present teachers as virtuous models and the "living curriculum."
- Parents & Community: emphasis on partnership with families, open communications, and community/stewardship through church-affiliated life and fundraising; MSDE/NAPCIS recognition cited publicly.

Abstract: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials frame Annunciation High School as Catholic and liturgically integrated, with statements about being "a classical school rooted in the Catholic faith" and alignment with the Magisterium. Daily Mass, confession, and liturgical practices are described, including weekly Adoration and Examen instruction.

- The school emphasizes Catholic formation as foundational to the educational enterprise.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: truth, goodness, beauty; theology; liturgy; Mass; Rosary; sacred tradition; Magisterium; Catholic faith; sacramental life; prayerful formation; examen;

adoration. These map directly to the Positive Keywords for Religious & Metaphysical Foundations in the Six Essential Elements framework. - Negative keywords: not present in public materials (no strong signals of secularism or value-neutral education in these public materials).

Why this rating - The materials consistently foreground transcendental aims (truth, goodness, beauty) and a liturgical, sacramental Catholic life. The alignment with theology and liturgical practices is explicit, consistent with a Classical Catholic foundation. Therefore, CLASSICAL.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Admissions rhetoric specifies formation in wisdom and virtue through study of the true, the good, and the beautiful; the public materials treat education as formation rather than mere information. - The school explicitly positions classical education as the aim, with formation of human excellence in view and a teleological orientation toward truth, goodness, and beauty.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, telos, pursuit of truth/goodness/beauty, humane letters, moral imagination, contemplation. These align with Positive Keywords for School Purpose and Goal in the Six Essential Elements. - Negative keywords: absent in public materials (no emphasis on career-readiness or purely job-focused outcomes).

Why this rating - The school's stated goal is formation and moral/philosophical cultivation rather than job placement or purely utilitarian aims. This aligns with classical aims of paideia and human flourishing, supporting a CLASSICAL rating.

Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials describe a classical curriculum rooted in Catholic faith and refer to a liberal-arts rooted program; the curriculum is described as classical, with Socratic inquiry noted as a method for arriving at truth.

- The curriculum page signals engagement with the Great Conversation by highlighting the classical approach and the use of the Socratic method to engage with great thinkers and texts.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Quadrivium), Great Books / Great Conversation, primary texts, historical depth, interdisciplinary integration, wonder, justified by the public materials and the curriculum PDF references. The materials also emphasize a guaranteed classical approach rooted in Western intellectual tradition. - Negative keywords: not evident in public materials; no signals of a purely modern or STEM-first curriculum dominating the program (public materials emphasize classical and Catholic formation).

Why this rating - The presence of classical framing (classical curriculum; Socratic method; Great Books orientation implied) strongly supports CLASSICAL in Curriculum.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials explicitly mention the Socratic method as a means to arrive at truth through dialogue and questions. This aligns with high-school classical pedagogy in the upper grades. - Indirect signals of pedagogy include a formation-focused approach, and the presence of liturgical and contemplative elements suggests a balance of rigorous inquiry with contemplative education (Scholé-like elements are implied through rest and ritual life, though not exhaustively cataloged publicly). - There is explicit reference to a classical curriculum and a foundation in the Catholic tradition, with teachers who model virtue and mentorship (see Faculty section).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Socratic dialogue/seminars, dialectic, great conversation, guided discussion, logical reasoning, rhetoric, memorization/recitation signals (through public mention of a classical pedagogy), scholé/restful learning (implied by liturgical and contemplative practices; see Six Elements' Pedagogy signals). - Negative keywords: The public materials do not emphasize purely project-based or experiential-only pedagogy; however, the public materials do not always explicitly catalog the full spectrum of classical pedagogy signals (e.g., dedicated notes on memorization chants, formal scholé days). The absence of explicit exhaustive descriptions means signals are partial rather than comprehensive.

Why this rating - The clear inclusion of Socratic/Dialogic pedagogy and classical aims places the school solidly in the classical pedagogy domain, but the public documentation does not exhaustively demonstrate every facet (e.g., explicit scholé days or full recitation/memory work practices). Thus, SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than fully CLASSICAL at this moment, given the public documentation.

Note: If more explicit evidence of full scholé days or complete memorization/recitation routines were provided publicly, the category would shift toward CLASSICAL.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Faculty pages describe teachers as virtuous role models and living curriculum; a portrait of what a teacher should be and what a student should be is reflected in the site's language about teachers and staff. The public materials present faculty as mentors who embody and transmit classical formation. - Administrative leadership includes a President/Headmaster with theological credentials and a culture of virtuous teaching and formation; the faculty is described as "talented and dynamic," promising fidelity to Catholic Magisterium. - The staff pages emphasize alignment with faith, doctrine, and mentorship (e.g., theology and philosophy instruction by qualified staff).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: virtuous teachers, mentors, living curriculum, portrait of teacher, collegial culture, teacher-to-student ratio (1:12 in certain programs), fidelity to Magisterium. - Negative keywords: not evident in public materials; no signals of a purely secular or non-mentorship-focused faculty structure.

Why this rating - The public-facing materials portray a faculty that embodies classical and Catholic formation with explicit mentoring roles, living curriculum concepts, and fidelity to Catholic teaching. This supports CLASSICAL.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school emphasizes partnership with families and positions parents as co-educators in the classical education ethos; materials reference family involvement, book clubs, and parish/community alignment. - The school communicates with parents via newsletters, events, and community engagement (Monthly newsletters, Giving Day, admissions communication). The existence of a formal fundraising channel and community events is evidenced publicly. - The school is MSDE/NAPCIS recognized, indicating alignment with external standards relevant to parental trust and community legitimacy.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families; parental formation; family involvement; home-school connection; parent-teacher collaboration; open campus; community of learners; faith and family; parental leadership. These map to the Positive Keywords for Parents & Community in the Six Essential Elements. - Negative keywords: none evident in public materials (no consumerist or minimal-parent involvement signals).

Why this rating - Public materials depict a robust parent-and-community orientation with explicit partnership ethos, further strengthened by external recognition and engagement channels. This aligns with CLASSICAL.

What Would Move the Needle

- Not applicable since the aggregate rating is CLASSICAL across all six categories. No category currently requires needle-moving changes to reach CLASSICAL status; the school already exhibits strong alignment with the classical framework in religious life, formation aims, classical curriculum, and faculty/community integration.
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Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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